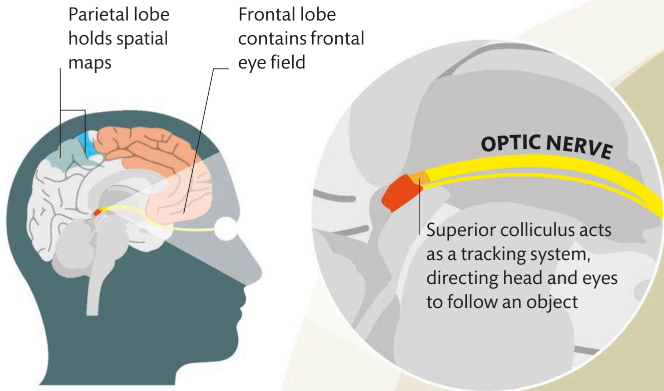
Paying attention

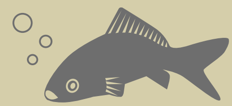
Attention directs our consciousness (see pp.162–163) to focus more intently on a particular sensory input, such as a sight or sound, and to tune out competing information. The process of paying attention begins with the sensory organs, which activate various areas of the brain, including the frontal and parietal lobes. The parietal lobe processes spatial information, directing attention to an area of space, while the frontal lobe directs the eyes to focus on specific objects.



Attention areas
Key to paying attention to visual stimuli is the frontal eye field, located in the frontal lobe, and the superior colliculus. Together, they instruct our eyes to focus on an object.

Attention

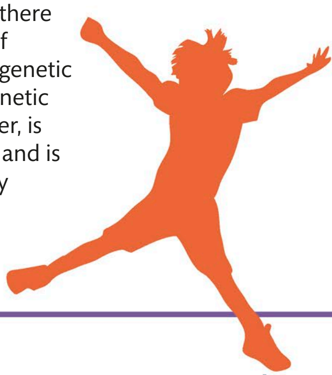
Attention is the process of concentrating or focusing on specific information. The brain is the main organ that processes both behavioral and cognitive information, although other parts of the body, such as the eyes and ears, are also required.



RESEARCH SUGGESTS THAT THE **AVERAGE** HUMAN **ATTENTION SPAN** IS JUST **8 SECONDS**

ATTENTION DEFICIT HYPERACTIVITY DISORDER

Attention deficit hyperactivity disorder (ADHD) is a behavioral disorder (see p.216) that includes symptoms such as inattentiveness and hyperactivity. The exact cause of ADHD is not yet fully understood. Research suggests that there may be an imbalance of neurotransmitters or a genetic cause. Any potential genetic cause of ADHD, however, is thought to be complex and is unlikely to be caused by a single gene.



ARE OUR ATTENTION SPANS SHRINKING?

There is no evidence that our individual attention spans are shrinking, but a recent study suggests that our collective attention span—how long as a society we focus on a news story or trending topic, for example—is decreasing.